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Applicant

Name: Dr. Christopher (Christopher) J Zorn

Award Information

Program: Fulbright U.S. Scholar Program

Award Cycle: 2027-2028

Country/Countries: Namibia

Award Title: All Disciplines

Award Number: 271224-NA

Multi-Country Award: No

Award Activity: Teaching/Research

Percent of Time on Activity: 50% / 50% (T/R)

(Teaching/Research only)

Project Information

(not applicable for International Education Administrator Awards)

Discipline: Law

Specialization: Judiciary System

Other Specializations:

Related: political science, applied statistics, computational linguistics, artificial intelligence.

Project Title:

Institutionalization and Change in the Supreme Court of Namibia

Project Abstract/Summary:

Using a mixed-method approach combining computational linguistics, public opinion surveys, elite interviews, and archival research, my project will trace the institutionalization of the Supreme Court of Namibia on four key dimensions: autonomy, adaptability, coherence, and complexity. I will also engage in an integrated program of teaching and mentoring in the University of Namibia's Faculty of Law, and outreach to the Namibian legal community, with the goal of strengthening judicial institutions, access to justice, and the rule of law.

Proposed Award Period

Start Date: January 2028

Length (Months): 10 months

Proposed Host Institution:

University of Namibia

Host Institution, Additional Comments:

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(not applicable for International Education Administrator Awards)

Flex

Flex is for projects that require multiple visits to the host country. This option allows awards to be conducted over two or three short segments.

Not all awards allow Flex. If Flex is allowed, applicants must select Flex in the application form, and clearly describe their plans for Flex in their project statement, including a project timeline.

Flex Allowed: No Segments Allowed: _____ Segments Proposed: No

Flex/Multi-Country Award Calendar (if applicable)

Proposed schedule for travel to the host country/countries.

Proposed Segment 1:	
Country:	Host Institution:
Start Date:	Length (Months):
Additional Comments:	
Proposed Segment 2 (if applicable)	
Country:	Host Institution:
Start Date:	Length (Months):
Additional Comments:	
Proposed Segment 3 (if applicable)	
Country:	Host Institution:
Start Date:	Length (Months):
Additional Comments:	

Applicants may propose affiliation with a hospital or clinic for independent or collaborative research and/or teaching. Awards shall not authorize activity for which a license to practice medicine or nursing is required. Scholars will need to abide by visa regulations put in place by the host country.

Proposed project will involve activities for which a license to practice may be required: No

If yes, explanation (up to 500 characters):

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Applicant: Zorn

Academic and Professional Information

(Refer to CV/Resume for additional information on employment and academic history)

Current Employment Information

Academic/Professional Title: Other Liberal Arts Professor

Institution/Employer: The Pennsylvania State University

School: College of Liberal Arts

Department: Department of Political Science

City, State, Country: University Park PA United States

Current Position Start Date: Jul 2010

Position Type: I am a tenure-line (tenure-track) faculty member (Assistant, Associate, Full)

Standard Breakdown of Responsibilities at Institution During Academic Year (if applicable):

Research: 50 % Teaching: 25 % Service: 25 %

Career Profile: I am a Senior Academic

U.S. Armed Forces: No If yes: U.S. Citizen: Yes

Academic History

Degree Requirement (per award): Ph.D. (or other terminal degree) required

Degree/Diploma: PhD
Institution (State/Country): Ohio State University-Main Campus Discipline: Political Science Date Received/Expected: 08/01/1997
Degree/Diploma: BA
Institution (State/Country): Truman State University Discipline: Political Science and Philosophy Date Received/Expected: 05/01/1991
Degree/Diploma:
Institution (State/Country): Discipline: Date Received/Expected:
Degree/Diploma:
Institution (State/Country): Discipline: Date Received/Expected:
Degree/Diploma:
Institution (State/Country): Discipline: Date Received/Expected:

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Applicant: Zorn **Award:** 271224-NA **Activity:** Teaching/Research

Previous Fulbright Grant(s)

Recipients of a Fulbright Scholar grant are eligible to apply for another Fulbright Scholar grant two years after the date of completion of the previous grant. (For Flex grants, the two-year period begins at the end of the final grant in the series.)

Applicant has previously completed or undertaken:

Fulbright Scholar grant(s): No

Includes: Fulbright U.S. Scholar (including Fulbright Distinguished Scholars and Chairs), International Education Administrator (IEA) Award, Fulbright Arctic Program, Fulbright Amazonia, German Studies Seminar, NEXUS, Fulbright Visiting Scholar, Scholar-in-Residence, and New Century Scholars.

Other types of Fulbright grant(s): No

Includes: Fulbright Student (Study/Research), Fulbright English Teaching Assistantship (ETA), Fulbright Specialist, Fulbright Teacher Exchange, Fulbright-Hays, Fulbright Foreign Student, Fulbright Foreign Language Teaching Assistant (FLTA).

Award Type: Country:	Year:
Award Type: Country:	Year:
Award Type: Country:	Year:
Award Type: Country:	Year:
Award Type: Country:	Year:

See Curriculum Vitae/Resume for additional grants, if applicable.

Justification

Applicants who have previously completed or undertaken Fulbright Scholar grant(s) are asked to provide compelling justification for an additional Fulbright Scholar grant.

Reason(s) selected (up to nine may be selected in the application):

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Applicant: Zorn **Award:** 271224-NA **Activity:** Teaching/Research

Accomplishments and Contributions from Previous Fulbright Scholar Grants

Applicant describes the accomplishments and contributions resulting from previous Fulbright Scholar grant(s), and how the proposed project will build on their previous Fulbright Scholar experience(s). (Up to 1,200 characters)

Experience Abroad

Applicants who have resided abroad for five or more years in the six-year period preceding the date of application are ineligible. A period of nine months or more during a calendar year is considered to constitute a full year abroad.

Applicant has resided or traveled abroad for five or more years in the last six years: No

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Language Proficiency

Proficiency in language(s) **other than English** is necessary for some, but not all awards; as part of their proposed project, scholars may engage with communities in which English may not be the first or primary language.

There are two parts to the language proficiency evaluation: a self-evaluation and an external foreign language evaluation; completion of each depends on the award requirements.

These evaluate the applicant's language proficiency **related to the proposed project**.

Per the award description, proficiency in a language other than English:

None, English is sufficient

(Award may indicate additional requirements.)

Award requirement: None, English is sufficient

- Self-Evaluation: *Required*: Applicant completes self-evaluation for language(s) relevant to proposed project
- Foreign Language Evaluation: Applicant should not register a Foreign Language evaluator

Award requirement: None, English is sufficient. However, feasibility of conducting the project must be demonstrated in the project statement

- Self-Evaluation: *Required*: Applicant completes self-evaluation for language(s) relevant to proposed project
- Foreign Language Evaluation: *Optional*: Applicant can register Foreign Language evaluator(s)

Award requirement: Recommended

- Self-Evaluation: *Required*: Applicant completes self-evaluation for language(s) relevant to proposed project
- Foreign Language Evaluation: *Recommended*: Applicant is encouraged to register Foreign Language evaluator(s)

Award requirement: Required

- Self-Evaluation: *Required*: Applicant completes self-evaluation for language(s) relevant to proposed project
- Foreign Language Evaluation: *Required*: Applicant must register Foreign Language evaluator(s)

Self-Evaluation

Up to three languages (other than English) relevant to proposed grant activity may be included.

Number of languages: 1

Language	Reading	Writing	Speaking
Other	Advanced	Advanced	Advanced

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Language proficiency for the proposed project:

(Required for all applicants)

Indicate if language proficiency is necessary for the proposed project to be feasible. If the applicant does not currently have the necessary language proficiency, indicate plans to ensure the feasibility of the project. Indicate if additional language study is progress or planned. (Up to 700 characters)

The proposed research project will require proficiency in R and possibly Python. I have proficiency in both of those languages.

Previous experience with language(s):

(Required if one or more languages are selected)

Indicate previous experience with the language(s): how the language was learned (formal study, self-study, mother tongue, spoken at home, studied/lived in country, etc.); how much time was spent in formal study and the level (e.g., number of semesters or years); if time was spent studying or living in a place where the language(s) were spoken; recent opportunities for reading and speaking the language(s), including lecturing; if a language proficiency test in the language(s) of the host country or countries has ever been taken (indicate the nature of the test(s), including when it was administered). (Applicants may not upload copies of test results.) (Up to 700 characters)

I am a native speaker of English. This award has no additional language requirements.

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Applicant: Zorn

Recommendations and Foreign Language Evaluation(s)

Recommendations

Two letters of recommendation are required.

Letters of recommendations evaluate the applicant's professional work, including the abilities and expertise they bring to the project; their ability to adapt; the merits of the project.

One letter should be from a colleague or supervisor at their current employer; the other should be from a colleague in their discipline (within or outside their employer).

Foreign Language Evaluations(s)

If foreign language evaluation(s) are necessary, up to two evaluators may provide evaluations (each language should be evaluated separately).

A qualified foreign language evaluator should be an instructor in the language or otherwise qualified to evaluate language proficiency.

Evaluators are asked to comment on the applicant's present language competence in the specified language (not English) relative to their proposed project.

Anyone who serves as a recommender may not also provide the applicant with an invitation letter or foreign language evaluation.

The following cannot serve as recommenders or language evaluators:
Relatives of the applicant; Representatives of the U.S. Embassy post and Fulbright Commission in the proposed host country (country of application); Representatives of the Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs (ECA) at the U.S. Department of State; and Representatives of the Institute of International Education, including current IIE staff, IIE Board of Trustees, and Fulbright Scholar Advisory Board (CIES) Members.

Name: Michael Nelson

Affiliation: Pennsylvania State University

Type: Letter of Recommendation

Name: Gregory Caldeira

Affiliation: Ohio State University

Type: Letter of Recommendation

Name:

Affiliation:

Type:

Name:

Affiliation:

Type:

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Applicant: Zorn **Award:** 271224-NA **Activity:** Teaching/Research

Ethical Requirements

Applicants proposing research involving human beings or animals as research subjects should have their projects vetted by the Institutional Review Board (IRB) at their home institutions. Pending selection, scholars may be required to obtain research clearance from the host country (where applicable).

Applicants not affiliated with an institution should conduct an individual ethics review ensuring that their proposed projects are consistent with ethical standards for research involving humans as research participants as outlined in the National Guidelines for Human Subjects Research (U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Grants and Funding, National Institutes of Health, https://grants.nih.gov/policy/humansubjects.htm), and in the National Guidelines for Animal Welfare at the National Institutes of Health's Office of Laboratory Animal Welfare (https://olaw.nih.gov/) or other applicable internationally recognized ethics guidance documents.

Human subjects research includes:

- Clinical investigations (any experiment or study on one or more persons which involves a test product/article, whether a drug, treatment, procedure or device);
- Social-behavioral studies which entail interaction with or observation of people, especially vulnerable populations (i.e., as minors, pregnant women, inmates, drug-users, the mentally impaired, displaced/refugee populations); and,
- Basic scientific research to study the biology of animals, persons or organs and specimens thereof.

The most fundamental issues in studies involving human research subjects include: valid scientific questions and approaches, potential social value, favorable risk-benefit ratio, fair selection of study participants, and an adequately administered informed consent process.

While IRB approval is not required at the time of application, scholars selected for grants must abide by all ethical requirements before commencing their research on human and/or animal subjects through a Fulbright award.

Data Privacy Consent for Applicants & Participants of IIE-Managed Programs

Applicant has read IIE's Program Privacy Statement and gives consent for IIE to process their data: Yes

Applicant Signature

By my signature below:

1. I have read and understood all instructions accompanying this application, including the section on Eligibility on the Fulbright U.S. Scholar website.
2. I certify that to the best of my knowledge, the information provided in my application is true, correct, and complete. All material is my own work. I understand it is unacceptable to misrepresent accomplishments, to borrow from the works of others without proper acknowledgment, or to submit as one's own material what has been written, re-written or heavily edited by others. Breaches of these protocols may result in rejection of the application.
3. I understand that any misrepresentation or omission may be cause for withdrawing a recommended status or grant award, in the event I am awarded a grant.
4. I understand that this application and supporting materials will be shared with those who are responsible for administering the Fulbright program or involved in the application and selection process, including persons involved in the peer review process and staff at the U.S. Department of State, Fulbright Commission and U.S. embassy in the country(s) to which I am applying.
5. I understand that additional documentation may be requested and, if I am selected for a grant, the terms of my grant could be altered based on those materials.
6. I understand that all Fulbright program grants are subject to the Policies of the Fulbright Foreign Scholarship Board.

Name: Christopher J Zorn Date: _____

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Applicant: Zorn

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Contact Information

Current Employment Address

Current Institution/Employer: The Pennsylvania State University

School: College of Liberal Arts

Department: Department of Political Science

Street: 545 Susan Welch Liberal Arts Building, 137 Fischer Roa City: University Park

State/Region: PA Postal Code: 16802 **Country**: United States

Permanent/Mailing Address (Residence)

Permanent Address

Country: United States of America

Street: 501 Glenn Rd

City: State College

State/Region: PA

Postal Code: 16803-3473

Mailing Address (if applicable)

Country: United States of America

Street: 501 Glenn Rd

City: State College

State/Region: PA

Postal Code: 16803-3473

Valid From: 03/01/2016 To:

Will resume residence in U.S. following Fulbright award: Yes

If no:

Currently living in host country OR, prior to proposed award start date, plans to reside in the host country (if yes, explain):

Telephone Numbers

Cell: +1 803-553-4077 Home: +1 803-553-4077 Work: +1 803-553-4077

Email

Primary: zorn@psu.edu Alternate: c.j.zorn@gmail.com

Emergency Contact

(An individual in the U.S. to be notified in case of emergency)

First Name: Lisa Last Name: Vebber

Street: 383 Ghaner Drive

City: State College State: PA Postal Code: 16801

Phone Number: +1 213-604-5819 Email: lvebber@me.com

Relationship to Applicant: Partner

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Applicant Personal Information

First Name: Christopher
Middle Name: J
Last Name: Zorn
Preferred Name: Christopher
Birthdate: 11/10/1968
Sex: Male
City, State/Region of Birth: Aurora, NE, United States
Country of Birth: United States
Primary Citizenship: United States
Other Citizenship:
Naturalized Citizen: No
Naturalization Date:

Citizenship/Residency Requirement for Selected Award:

Not applicable: all U.S. citizens are eligible to apply, regardless of dual citizenship or residency

Identify as having a disability: No

Dependent Information

If applicant expects dependent(s) to accompany them on the grant, they are listed below. Award description will indicate if dependents will be supported by the award.

Note: For the purposes of grant benefits, a dependent is either (1) a spouse or (2) a relative (child, grandchild, parent, or sibling) who is financially dependent on the applicant. Accompanying dependents are those who spend at least 80 percent of the grant period with the grantee abroad.

1-Name: Relationship:
Will accompany: DOB: School Grade:

2-Name: Relationship:
Will accompany: DOB: School Grade:

3-Name: Relationship:
Will accompany: DOB: School Grade:

4-Name: Relationship:
Will accompany: DOB: School Grade:

5-Name: Relationship:
Will accompany: DOB: School Grade:

6-Name: Relationship:
Will accompany: DOB: School Grade:

7-Name: Relationship:
Will accompany: DOB: School Grade:

8-Name: Relationship:
Will accompany: DOB: School Grade:

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Applicant: Zorn

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Employment Eligibility

Employees and their immediate families (i.e. spouses and dependent children) of the U.S. Department of State and of public or private organizations under contract to the U.S. Department of State are ineligible to apply for a Fulbright grant until one year after termination of such employment.

In the one year prior to the application deadline (see Award for the program deadline), has the applicant or an immediate family member (spouse or dependent children) been any of the following:

- An employee of the U.S. Department of State (paid or unpaid, including part-time or temporary employees, consultants, externs, fellows and contract employees; does not include interns);
- An employee of private and public agencies (excluding educational institutions) under contract to the U.S. Department of State to perform administrative or screening services on behalf of the Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs' exchange programs;
- An officer of an organization, in the U.S. or abroad, including members of boards of trustees or similar governing bodies, or individuals otherwise associated with the organization, wherein the organization and the individuals are responsible for nominating or selecting individuals for participation in any U.S. Department of State exchange program;
- A current board member or staff of the Institute of International Education or the Council for International Exchange of Scholars;
- A board member or staff of a Fulbright Commission;
- A member of the Fulbright Foreign Scholarship Board.
- An Alumni Ambassador for the Fulbright U.S. Scholar Program.

Response: No

If yes (350-character limit):

Felony/Misdemeanor/Misconduct

Applicants are required to disclose if they have ever been arrested for, indicted for, or charged with a felony or a misdemeanor (excluding minor traffic violations, juvenile convictions, or cases where the record has been sealed or expunged) or accused of misconduct (including but not limited to unethical practices, harassment, sexual harassment or abuse, or other misconduct that may have been the focus of some kind of inquiry or process). Applicants must promptly notify IIE in writing if they are arrested for, indicted for, charged with or convicted of a felony or misdemeanor (excluding minor traffic violations) after submitting the application. FFSB policies can be found here (https://eca.state.gov/fulbright/about-fulbright/fulbright-foreign-scholarship-board-ffsb/ffsb-policies, Chapter 600/Section 626 Ineligibility Factors.)

Submitted documentation will not be revealed to those reviewing the application during the Peer Review process or as a part of the host country selection process. However, statements and documents may be forwarded the Fulbright Foreign Scholarship Board for review and determination of eligibility.

Responses hidden for privacy.

Note to applicants: If you are arrested for, indicted for, charged with, or convicted of a felony or misdemeanor (excluding minor traffic violations), or accused of misconduct after the submission of this application, you must promptly inform IIE in writing (FulbrightScholarReview@iie.org).

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Essays

Country Selection (U.S. Scholar)

Applicant describes why this country (or countries) is the best match for their project; the experiences that have prepared them to undertake the project in this country (countries). (Up to 2,000 characters)

Namibia is, in a political sense, a young country; its Supreme Court is still becoming institutionalized, and that Court's public legitimacy is still very much in flux. And as I note in my project statement, Namibia's constitution also holds a number of unique characteristics that make it an especially valuable locus of study. In addition, the skills in elite interviewing, computational linguistics, archival research, and data analysis that I have developed over the course of my career ideally position me for the research component of the award.

Similarly, my interdisciplinary teaching experience (encompassing law, political science, information science, and applied statistics) will allow me to move across UNAM's different departments, working with students in a range of disciplines and building bridges across fields. Contemporary and future legal practice is increasingly dependent on the adept use of technological tools. By orienting my teaching across the fields in which I work, my project will enable future leaders in the law to do their work more efficiently and effectively.

In addition, Namibian legal institutions—including the Court, but also legal education, the bar, and legal services organizations—are key players in the country's continued (successful) development and maintenance of civil society. The durability of Namibia's democratic consolidation is itself something of a puzzle, and likely turns critically on organizations like the Law Society and the Legal Assistance Centre maintaining public confidence in the rule of law. My work will simultaneously help in understanding the roles of those entities in Namibia's ongoing success, and foster their continued health and growth. Lastly, in a different vein: Having grown up in central Nebraska, I have a strong affinity for Namibia's wide open spaces; I expect it will feel very much like home in that regard.

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Why Fulbright? (U.S. Scholar)

Applicant describes why Fulbright and why now, and how this in terms of their career path and future goals. (Up to 1,500 characters)

Because my professional career has been primarily focused on the United States, I learned of the Fulbright U.S. Scholars program only recently. With respect to research, the Fulbright is a natural outgrowth of my expanding inquiry into the development of political institutions. Interestingly, the struggles for U.S. and Namibian independence both lasted about the same amount of time (roughly 24 years, from the origins of their respective movements to their successful conclusions), albeit nearly 200 years apart, and their respective high courts have played central roles in the stability and flourishing of the two systems. In the U.S., I have spent years growing my ethnographic knowledge of that body: its norms, practices, and folkways. The political, legal, and institutional development of Namibia offers an opportunity to examine a system in its formative stages, one that has not yet survived and adapted over decades of social change. To do so requires that I develop the same depth and breadth of knowledge of those institutions that I currently have for those in the U.S.

My domestic focus has also meant that my teaching and my outreach have often been geared towards narrower, more abstract concerns, with limited real-world effect. As I move into the later stages of my career, I view the Fulbright as an opportunity to foster more transformative change in my teaching and community engagement, and in doing so to make a real, meaningful impact on Namibians' lives.

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Cultural Preparation (U.S. Scholar)

The Fulbright Program is designed to expand and strengthen relationships between the people of the United States and citizens of other nations and to promote international understanding and cooperation. During their awards, Fulbrighters will meet, engage with, and learn from the people of the host country.

Applicant describes their familiarity with the host culture, and any other global experiences that prepare them to adjust successfully to life in the host country, including prior experiences in the host country/countries (if any); how they will adapt to working and living in the host country; how their experience prepares them to represent the U.S. as a cultural ambassador (including specific examples); and how they plan to share their culture and values, and learn from others. (Up to 2,000 characters)

Put simply, I do not have prior experience living in, working in, or visiting Namibia. Through self-study, I have become familiar with Namibian colonial and post-colonial history, and have invested in learning about Namibian institutions, culture (including music, film, and literature), and social norms. The Fulbright is, at a personal level, a means of growth: of intellectual, pedagogical, and cultural stretching that will push my own boundaries as a scholar, teacher, and community member. The program will also allow me to bring my own experience researching and working in U.S. government institutions to the Namibian capital. As the program officer for Law and Social Sciences at the U.S. National Science Foundation, I managed a federal interdisciplinary grant office that supported work on legal systems, access to justice, and the rule of law, as well as conducting outreach to domestic legal and academic communities. That experience puts me in a strong position to represent the United States as a cultural ambassador to the Namibian legal communities. Moreover, having navigated the shift from academic to government and private-sector life and back again, I am well practiced at adapting to new institutional cultures, a skill I expect my Namibian colleagues will help me put to immediate use.

At the same time, my desire for cultural as well as academic engagement is arguably an even more important part of my motivation for seeking a Fulbright. My own personal interests—cycling, music performance, cooking, sport fishing, and soccer—are widely shared in Namibia, and I will continue to pursue those interests during my time as a Fulbright U.S. Scholar. As a guitarist, I am especially eager to engage with members of the Shambo community in Windhoek, where that traditional form has integrated with other contemporary genres, including hip-hop and jazz. I foresee developing connections with local artists as a crucial part of transitioning to working and living in the country.

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Teaching Preparation (U.S. Scholar)

Applicant describes how they will make their teaching relevant to the culture(s) and language(s) of the host country (or countries), and how they will adapt their materials and pedagogy to a different teaching environment in which students' first language may not be English. (*This essay is only completed by applicants who selected Teaching or Teaching/Research award activity.*) (Up to 1,500 characters)

One of my great joys in teaching is the learning that accompanies it. In three decades, I have never taught a course or seminar without coming away changed: smarter, more challenged, more thoughtful than before. I approach every class with the goal of learning as much as I teach. Central to that goal is placing the materials in context. For my classes on methodology, this means applications that speak to the students' worlds and experiences. In more substantive courses, it requires seeking out situational knowledge from which broader lessons can be drawn.

My strategy for accomplishing these goals has always been one of engagement: I ask questions, elicit examples, and learn terms and practices I can incorporate into my teaching. While the analogy is imperfect, my decade-plus tenure at GSERM is informative. Students there are primarily German-speakers from central Europe; pedagogically, I begin by asking for examples of phenomena that fit my instructional goals, which I then use in class discussions, exercises, and examinations. Taking an active interest in my students' lives, rather than just "importing" content from outside their experience, both improves their understanding and instills a sense of efficacy and relevance that builds confidence and trust. I believe this approach will be especially fruitful at UNAM's Faculty of Law, whose central purpose is training individuals for the protection and promotion of human rights, the rule of law, and democracy in Namibia.

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Fulbright U.S. Scholar Award

Project Statement

Dr. Christopher Zorn
Liberal Arts Professor, Department of Political Science
Affiliate Professor of Law and Information Science & Technology
Pennsylvania State University

Proposed Project: Institutionalization and Change in the Supreme Court of Namibia

Introduction

On March 21, 1990, the world witnessed the creation of a new constitutional court. The end of the three-decade struggle for Namibian independence saw the creation of the Namibian Supreme Court. Unlike other similar institutions created around that time (for example, in Eastern Europe), the Court was a wholly novel institution; prior to independence, final appeals from the territory of South West Africa went not to any Namibian court but to the Appellate Division in Bloemfontein. The Namibian Supreme Court thus had to forge its own path, both with respect to its jurisprudence and as a political institution operating in a newborn constitutional system. That it has done so is both a cause and a consequence of Namibia's remarkable thirty-five-year history as a stable, successful model of peaceful democratic transition and rule.

For more than three decades, my career has comprised research and teaching on political institutions, and in particular on courts and other judicial bodies. Much of my work has been U.S.-focused, a fact that has had both advantages and drawbacks. While the long history and relative organizational equilibrium of the U.S. system are a boon to understanding its operation and influence, it also makes research on institutional development and change more difficult. My interest in the Namibian Supreme Court stems in part from the opportunity it provides to understand how an important, emergent institution changes and develops in its earliest days.

Driven by both scholarly and pedagogical interests, my application to the Fulbright U.S. Scholars Program at the University of Namibia (UNAM) contemplates an integrated program of teaching, outreach, and research, one that will substantially benefit the university, the greater Namibian population, and U.S.-Namibian relations. Consistent with the award description, I anticipate spending roughly equal time on teaching and research, with substantial additional effort geared towards outreach to the Namibian political and legal communities, and toward mentoring and public engagement; I describe each of these tracks in detail below.

Research

The research focus of my proposed Fulbright is the institutionalization of the Namibian Supreme Court. As a concept, institutionalization has its roots in early sociological theories of Weber, Parsons, and others; Eisenstadt defined it as "the organization of a societally prescribed system of differentiated behavior oriented to the solution of certain problems inherent in a major area of social life." More concretely, McGuire notes that a political body is institutionalized "to the extent that it is an integrated part of the governmental system with an identity or mission seen as uniquely its own." Institutionalization thus represents a key characteristic of the legitimate,

effective political institutions necessary for democracy to thrive. For a legislature, an agency, or a court to become institutionalized requires that it manifest and develop a set of characteristics to cement its place in the constitutional structure. Key among those are *autonomy* (sometimes styled as *differentiation*), *adaptability*, *coherence*, and *complexity*. Each of these four dimensions plays a key role in an institution assuming its place in the larger system of which it is a part, and each manifests itself in (qualitatively and quantitatively) measurable ways.

Central to the institutionalization of political bodies are the formal rules under which they exist and operate. In the case of the Namibian Supreme Court, for example, Article 144 of the Namibian Constitution specifies that "(U)nless otherwise provided by this Constitution or Act of Parliament, the general rules of public international law and international agreements binding upon Namibia under this Constitution shall form part of the law of Namibia." This clause mandates a particular form of constitutional monism, whereby the terms of international treaties binding on Namibia flow into domestic law automatically, without any action by the President or the parliament. It thus constitutes an independent source of constitutional power for the Supreme Court, one which in turn contributes to the Court's relative autonomy vis-à-vis the other branches of government. More broadly, constitutional rules, historical practices, and evolving norms all contribute to the speed, consistency, and durability of institutionalization of a particular organization. Moreover, political institutionalization occurs not only across organizations but also among the citizenry; a crucial component of institutionalization is the popular legitimacy of and confidence in the institution in question.

To trace the institutionalization of the Namibian Supreme Court, I will adopt a mixed-methods approach, one that combines quantitative and computational methods with in-depth historical research and personal interviews. Quantitatively, my research will draw on two major sources of data. The first is the entire corpus of existing decisions of the Namibian Supreme Court. I have secured an agreement with the nonprofit organization `Laws.Africa`, which has provided me with the full text and metadata of every decision of the Court; these will be supplemented with lower court decisions, legislation, and law reform reports secured through the Namibia Legal Information Institute (NamibLII). I have conducted computational linguistic analyses of large-scale databases of legal text for more than a decade; my analysis of the `Laws.Africa` and NamibLII data will encompass both token-based techniques and contemporary large language models for operationalization and measurement of key concepts.

The second source of quantitative data is the series of ten surveys of the Namibian population conducted between 1999 and 2024 by the Afrobarometer project.[1] Each of those ten surveys has included consistently-worded items about President-Court relations, and about the Court's ability to make decisions that are binding on the other branches and the people. By analyzing cross-sectional and temporal patterns of responses to these questions, I will establish and describe the extent and timing of the Court's institutionalization among members of the Namibian mass public.

Qualitatively, my research will combine textual insights from the development of the Court's jurisprudence with in-depth, structured and semi-structured interviews and archival research into historical documents relating to the Court's creation and development. The relative youth of the Namibian Supreme Court means that many of the individuals involved in its inception can be interviewed, including former and current justices as well as members of the

[1] It is likely that the Afrobarometer will add an eleventh wave to its Namibian surveys during 2027 or 2028, in which case I will incorporate those data into the project as well.

Law Society of Namibia (the country's official bar organization). Both the Court and the Society are located in Windhoek, and conduct their business in English, making interviews logistically straightforward. My own experience with conducting elite interviews is extensive, ranging from U.S. state legislators, federal Court of Appeals judges, and U.S. Solicitors General to managing partners of major U.S. law firms. My interviews will be augmented with historical research undertaken at the National Archives of Namibia, and at the Namibian Office of the Judiciary, both of which are also located in Windhoek. The eventual goal of this research will be the publication of a scholarly monograph with a major university or commercial press, one that will be of importance both within and outside of Namibia.

Teaching and Outreach

Over the course of my career, I have taught courses at all levels of the university, in subjects ranging from law, statistics, and computational linguistics to politics, public policy, and artificial intelligence. At UNAM, my goal is to work to bridge the schools and faculties, with a particular focus on the university's distinguished Faculty of Law. That Faculty is home to hundreds of young future leaders, including both graduate and undergraduate students; a striking number of its alumni have gone on to hold important positions in Namibian government and society, including Penny Iivula-Ithana, Monica Geingos, Peya Mushelenga, and Bernadus Swartbooi. Together with the Department of Political Science, the Law Faculty is at the core of Namibia's political future.

In addition, my own teaching philosophy strongly aligns with that of UNAM. At its core is the notion that instilling critical thinking, adaptability, and the capacity to learn and develop research skills over a lifetime is the central pedagogical task in the social and behavioral sciences. In a world of rapid social, technological, and economic change, the ideal preparation is for uncertainty: those best positioned to succeed, thrive, and shape the future are those with the intellectual agility to foresee change and dynamically adapt to it. This philosophy in turn drives my student-centered approach to learning, with a strong emphasis on individualized interaction, mentorship, and topical foci tailored to the specific needs of the student.

While at UNAM, I will be sponsored by Dr. Kennedy Kariseb, Associate Dean of the School of Law. In addition, I will collaborate with members of the Department of Political Science, as well as those in the Department of Computing, Mathematical and Statistical Science, to offer courses that bridge statistical science, legal informatics, and public policy. Depending on existing needs and offerings, these will include undergraduate courses that emphasize social scientific theories of institutional change and resilience, research methods skills, and critical artificial intelligence (AI) literacy. At the graduate level, the emphasis will be on designing, conducting, and disseminating policy-relevant research on political and civil society institutions in Namibia, including the courts, the bureaucracy, the bar, and non-profit and international organizations, and on courses that impart critical statistical and computational skills. The details of these courses will be developed in coordination with the faculty at UNAM, to ensure their consistency with the University's and its students' priorities, needs, and requirements. But examples may include undergraduate and/or graduate courses on *Judicial Politics in Comparative Perspective*, *Applied Statistics for Legal and Political Research*, and/or a seminar on *Computational Text Analysis for Law and Policy*. Beyond classroom instruction, I will also engage with supervision of graduate theses and research projects, with the goal of strengthening my ties to young scholars in the country.

In addition to teaching, I will undertake a sustained program of outreach to the political, legal, and educational communities in Windhoek. Some of this outreach will involve public-facing lectures and roundtables hosted by UNAM. In addition, I am particularly enthusiastic to work with members of the Namibian bar, and to focus on the ways in which recent changes in information technology and legal analytics can streamline and democratize the provision of legal services. While the Namibian Constitution guarantees equal access to justice, substantial practical barriers to achieving that access persist. Working with the Law Society and related groups (such as the Legal Assistance Centre, a non-profit public interest law firm dedicated to expanding access to justice), I will collaborate with the local legal community to advance reforms that improve access to legal services, particularly among the disadvantaged.

The timeline for my proposed research, teaching, and outreach activities as a Fulbright U.S. Scholar is outlined in Table 1.

Table 1: Proposed Research and Teaching Timeline

Fulbright Period	Research: Quantitative	Research: Qualitative	Teaching and Outreach
January-February 2028	Begin coding for Supreme Court case data; gather Afrobarometer data.	Begin scheduling Court interviews, subject to specific session terms and Court rolls.	Arrival; first semester courses begin; initiate outreach to legal services community.
March-April 2028	Continue coding Supreme Court data; begin coding NamibLII data; undertake analysis of Afrobarometer data.	Begin Court interviews; schedule interviews with Supreme Court bar and legal experts.	Invited lectures commence; continue access to justice collaboration.
May-June 2028	Draft analysis of Court and NamibLII data; write and present analysis of Afrobarometer data.	Continue Court and bar interviews; commence archival research.	First semester concludes; continue access to justice collaboration.
July-August 2028	Write and present analysis of Supreme Court and NamibLII data; revise Afrobarometer analysis.	Conclude Court interviews; continue bar interviews and archival research.	Second semester begins; invited lectures continue; begin implementing access to justice reforms.
September-October 2028	Integrate quantitative components into draft manuscript.	Conclude bar interviews and archival research; begin integration of qualitative findings.	Invited lectures conclude; second semester concludes; departure.

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Impact

The overarching goal of my Fulbright fellowship is to integrate the research, teaching, and outreach components into a program of work that will benefit myself, UNAM, the people of Namibia, and U.S.-Namibian relations more generally. The impact of this program will be felt on a number of different dimensions.

Research Impact: The proposed work on institutionalization offers important insights into the development of constitutional courts in the Global South. Namibia's constitution is the fifth-oldest in Africa, having lasted more than three times longer than the continental average. The Court's role in that remarkable persistence is of central importance to our understanding of what makes democracies last. The lessons we may learn from Namibia's success can inform the development of democratic constitutional systems around the world.

Teaching Impact: The growth of generative technologies means that integrating broad theoretical perspectives, qualitative and data analytic skills, and deep on-the-ground knowledge is the future of social-scientific work. Through collaborative, interdisciplinary lectures, courses, and projects that span the humanities, science, and law, I will offer UNAM students expertise from my own career in research and pedagogy. Even more important, the insights those students bring to my classrooms will inform and enhance both my own work and the teaching I do there and elsewhere. Finally, my Fulbright will lay the groundwork for reciprocal exchange between UNAM and Pennsylvania State University, in the form of future sponsorship of Fulbright students and faculty. Of particular importance here is Penn State's highly regarded African Studies program, which offers a dual-title Ph.D. with my own department, and which is actively seeking to admit graduate students from sub-Saharan Africa.

Institutional Impact: UNAM's position at the pinnacle of Namibian higher education makes it an innovator in research, instruction, and societal value. An important goal of my application is to build and strengthen connections across the University's various faculties, and in doing so to enhance pedagogical and research-aligned interdisciplinarity. My experience creating and building interdisciplinary programs and teams (e.g., the *Arbitrator Intelligence Project* at Penn State's Dickinson School of Law, and the University's *Center for Social Data Analytics*) puts me in an especially strong position to achieve this goal.

Personal Impact: Beyond research and teaching, my personal goal for my Fulbright Fellowship is to develop a set of relationships with individuals and organizations in Namibia that will allow me to deepen my understanding of Namibian institutions, politics, and culture, and thus to continue to teach, conduct research, and engage with the country and its people well into the future. I view this Fulbright as the beginning of a career-long collaboration into the history, development, and future direction of governance in the region.

Impact on U.S.-Namibian Relations: Recent developments in U.S.-Namibian diplomacy have called into question America's dedication to an autonomous, prosperous future for the Namibian people, and to liberal democracy, civil society, and the rule of law more broadly in the world. In seeking this Fulbright Fellowship, I aim to play a small role in restoring—and building—trust and goodwill between our two countries. In recent decades, sustained scholarly engagement has been one of the most durable expressions of the U.S.-Namibian relationship. By focusing on the strength and resilience of Namibian institutions, and by engaging deeply with Namibian educational, governmental, and civil society organizations, I hope to manifest and reinforce the U.S.'s commitment to a propitious, flourishing Namibia.

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Christopher Zorn

Curriculum Vitae

September 15, 2026

Affiliation

Department of Political Science
Pennsylvania State University
University Park, PA
USA

Education

Ph.D., Political Science. Ohio State University, Columbus, Ohio, 1997.

B.A., Northeast Missouri State University, Kirksville, Missouri, 1991.

Current Employment

- Liberal Arts Professor, Department of Political Science, Pennsylvania State University, 2010-present.
    - Graduate Faculty and Program Committee, Center for Social Data Analytics, Pennsylvania State University.
    - Professor (by courtesy), Penn State Law.
    - Professor (by courtesy), Department of Sociology and Criminology, Pennsylvania State University.
    - Affiliate Professor, College of Information Sciences and Technology, Pennsylvania State University.
    - Faculty Affiliate, Institute for Computational and Data Sciences, Pennsylvania State University.
    - Faculty Affiliate, Social Science Research Institute, Pennsylvania State University.
    - Faculty Affiliate, Center for Socially Responsible Artificial Intelligence, Pennsylvania State University.
- Lecturer, Global School in Empirical Research Methods (GSERM), University of St. Gallen, 2015-present.

Previous Employment

- Lecturer, ICPSR Summer Program in Quantitative Methods of Social Research, University of Michigan. 2000-2011, 2014-2017.

- Associate Professor and Professor, Department of Political Science, University of South Carolina. 2005-2007 (Department Vice-Chair, 2006-2007).
- Visiting Scientist and Program Director, Law and Social Sciences Program, National Science Foundation. 2003-2005.
- Assistant, Associate, and Winship Distinguished Research Professor, Department of Political Science, Emory University. 1996-2005 (on leave, 2003-2005).

Selected / Relevant Publications

- Zorn, Christopher. 2026. "Socialization and Dissent on the U.S. Supreme Court." *Open Judicial Politics*, 4th Ed., forthcoming.
- Rice, Douglas, and Christopher Zorn. 2025. "Divergence or Dysfunction? Using LLMs to Measure Disagreement on the U.S. Supreme Court." *Journal of Political Institutions and Political Economy* 6(3-4):329-354.
- Gill, Rebecca, and Christopher Zorn. 2021. "Overcoming the Barriers to Comparative Judicial Behavior Research." In Gill, Rebecca, Nuno Garoupa, and Lydia Tiede, eds. *High Courts in Global Perspective: Evidence, Methodologies, and Findings*. Charlottesville: University of Virginia Press.
- Rice, Douglas R., and Christopher Zorn. 2021. "Corpus-Based Dictionaries for Sentiment Analysis of Specialized Vocabularies." *Political Science Research and Methods* 9(1):20-35.
- Peppers, Todd C., Katherine O'Harra Vigilante, and Christopher Zorn. 2012. "Random Chance or Loaded Dice? Looking for the Hidden Politics of Judicial Designation." *University of New Hampshire Law Review* 10(1): 69-96.
- Zorn, Christopher, and Jennifer Bowie. 2010. "Ideological Influence in the Federal Judicial Hierarchy: An Empirical Assessment." *Journal of Politics* 72(4): 1212-1221.
- Iqbal, Zaryab, and Christopher Zorn. 2010. "Violent Conflict and the Spread of HIV/AIDS in Africa." *Journal of Politics* 72(1): 149-162.

Selected Current Working Papers

- "The Supreme Court As A National Policy Enabler." With Morrgan Herlihy. Paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, April 23-25, 2026, Chicago, IL, and at the 2025 Forum on American Institutional Renewal (FAIR) conference, Purdue University, May 28-29, 2025, West Lafayette, IN.
- "An Automated Topic Coding Tool for State Legislative Activity." With Jennie Sweet-Cushman and Rebecca Gill. Paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the Southern Political Science Association, January 15-18, 2026, New Orleans, LA.
- "A Typology of National High Courts in Africa." With Dominique Lewis. Presented at the Conference on Facilitating Empirical Studies of Judicial Behavior on Constitutional Courts from a Comparative Perspective, Texas A&M School of Law, Fort Worth, TX, May 11-12,

2018. (Supported by NSF SES-1744299), and at the Annual Meeting of the Southern Political Science Association, January 2018.

Selected Grants, Fellowships, and Awards

- 2026 Jewell Limar Prestage Best Paper Award for the best paper on the intersection of gender, race, ethnicity, and political behavior presented at the Annual Meeting of the Southwestern Political Science Association. For "Gender and the Misperception of Women's Representation in State Legislatures and Congress," with Jennie Sweet-Cushman and Rebecca Gill.
- AI in Instruction Microgrant, "Assessing The Impact of Course-Based Innovation on AI Literacy in the Social and Behavioral Sciences." 2026. AI Center of Excellence for Teaching and Learning, Pennsylvania State University.
- National Science Foundation SES-1144860 (Social, Behavioral, and Economic Sciences), "IGERT: Big Data Social Science - An Integrative Education and Research Program in Social Data Analytics." Senior personnel (PI: Burt Monroe).
- National Science Foundation SES-0835882 (Law and Social Science), "Decision Making in the Federal Judicial Hierarchy." 2007-2009. (REU Supplement SES-0836711 awarded 6/9/2008; REG Supplement SES-0932659 awarded 3/26/2009). PI.
- National Science Foundation SES-0720072 (Political Science and Methodology, Measurement, and Statistics), "Item Response Theory Models for Mixtures of Dominance and Proximity Items." 2007-2009. Co-PI (with Brian Habing).
- Karl Emil Wilde Lecture, University of St. Gallen, June 14, 2017.
- John M. Olin Foundation Faculty Fellowship, 1998-1999.

Amicus Curiae Briefs

- Brief of Computational Law Scholars as Amici Curiae in Support of Respondents, *State of Georgia et al. v. Public.Resource.Org, Inc.*. United States Supreme Court, no. 18-1150 (2019).
- Brief of Amici Curiae Political Science Professors in Support of Petitioner, *League of Women Voters of Pennsylvania v. Commonwealth of Pennsylvania*. Supreme Court of Pennsylvania, No. 159 MM 2017 (2018). (Brief mentioned in oral arguments.)
- Brief Of Deans And Professors Of Law, Economics, And Political Science Studying Judicial Elections As Amici Curiae In Support Of Respondent, *Williams-Yulee v. The Florida Bar*. United States Supreme Court, no. 13-1499 (2015). (Brief cited in Justice Ginsburg's opinion concurring in part and concurring in the judgment.)

Selected Professional Activities

- Treasurer, Research Committee on Comparative Judicial Studies (RC09), International Political Science Association. 2022-present.
- Co-Editor, *Empirical Legal Studies* Blog, 2007-present.
- Editorial board, *Law and Politics Book Review*, Organized Section on Law and Courts, American Political Science Association. 2016-2023.
- Advisory committee, International Methods Colloquium, 2014-2022. Funded under NSF award SES-1423825.
- Co-PI and Faculty Affiliate, Big Data Social Science IGERT, 2012-2019.
- Vice-President, Midwest Political Science Association, 2013-2016.
- Editor Search Committee, *American Political Science Review*, 2014-2015.
- Chair, Organized Section on Law and Courts, American Political Science Association, 2011-12.
- Member, ICPSR Governing Council, 2008-2012.
- Editor-in-Chief, *Political Analysis*, 2007-2009.
- Member, Executive Council, Midwest Political Science Association, 2005-2008.
- Instructor, ESRC Oxford Spring School in Quantitative Methods for Social Research, Oxford University.
- Invited research presentations (last ten years): University of Oklahoma (April 2025), University of Virginia School of Law (February 2025), Oregon State University (January 2023), Ohio State University - Mershon Center (July 2022), Texas A&M University (April 2016), University of Colorado - Boulder (February 2016), Iowa State University (January 2016).

Selected Courses Taught

- Social Data, Technology, and Artificial Intelligence (Undergraduate Seminar).
- Constitutional Law (Advanced Undergraduate Seminar).
- Civil Liberties (Advanced Undergraduate Seminar).
- American Judicial Behavior (Advanced Undergraduate Seminar).
- Empirical Legal Studies (Advanced / Analytic Undergraduate Seminar).
- Political Science Methods (Advanced Undergraduate Seminar).
- Judicial Politics (Graduate Seminar).
- Statistical Methods for Political Research (Graduate Seminar).
- Advanced Topics in Regression Analysis (Graduate Seminar).

- Time Series and Longitudinal Data Analysis (Graduate Seminar).
- Big Data and the Law (Graduate Seminar).
- Modern Measurement (Graduate Seminar).
- Regression For Publishing (GSERM Short Course).
- Analyzing Panel Data (GSERM Short Course).
- Maximum Likelihood Estimation for Generalized Linear Models (ICPSR Summer Course).
- Advanced MLE - Survival Models and Panel/TSCS Models (ICPSR Summer Course).

Ph.D. Thesis Committees (last 10 years)

- Morrgan Herilhy (Ph.D. 2026, Political Science, Pennsylvania State University). Louisiana State University.
- Kayla Kahn (Ph.D. 2025, Political Science, Pennsylvania State University). Verasight Inc.
- Jordan Zvonkovich (ABD, Sociology, Pennsylvania State University). Pennsylvania Commission on Sentencing.
- Nathan Morse (Ph.D. 2024, Political Science, Pennsylvania State University) (chair). U.S. Department of the Census.
- Mikaela Karstens (formerly Westhoff) (Ph.D. 2022, Pennsylvania State University). Data scientist, Siemens Energy.
- Nicholas Dietrich (Ph.D. 2020, Political Science, Pennsylvania State University). Assistant Professor of Data Analytics, Ohio Wesleyan University.
- John Schoeneman (Ph.D. 2019, Political Science, Pennsylvania State University) (chair). Assistant professor, Oklahoma State University.
- Julia Laskorunsky (Ph.D. 2017, Sociology, Pennsylvania State University). Research Director, The Robina Institute (University of Minnesota).
- Joshua Semat (Ph.D. 2017, Political Science, Pennsylvania State University). Senior Business Analyst, MITRE.
- Zachary Jones (Ph.D. 2017, Political Science, Pennsylvania State University). Senior data scientist, Amazon.
- Robert Richards (Ph.D. 2016, Communications Arts and Sciences, Pennsylvania State University). Associate professor, Clinton School of Public Service, University of Arkansas at Little Rock.
- Muhammed Idris (Ph.D. 2016, Political Science, Pennsylvania State University) (chair). Assistant professor, Morehouse School of Medicine and Founding Co-Director, Center of Excellence for the Validation of Digital Health Technologies and Clinical Algorithms.

Selected Professional Service (last 10 years)

- Penn State Academic Portfolio and Program Review (APPR), Data and Information Team (2024-2025).
- University Standing Joint Committee on Tenure, 2022-2025 (chair, 2022-2025).
- University Faculty Senate, 2017-2024.
    - University Faculty Senate Liaison to the Graduate Council, 2024.
    - Standing Committee on Research, Scholarship, and Creative Accomplishments, 2017-2024 (vice-chair, 2021-2023).
    - "The Impact of the COVID-19 Pandemic on Research at Penn State." Report of the Standing Committee on Research, Scholarship, and Creative Accomplishments to the Penn State University Senate, April 16, 2024. (Study PI, director, sole author.)
- University Promotion and Tenure Review Committee, 2020-2022.
- University Graduate Council, Ad Hoc Committee on the Impacts of COVID-19 on Graduate Education at Penn State (2020-present).

Selected Private and Non-Profit Sector Activities

- InStats (2024-present) (expert).
- DiversityLab (2021-present) (scientific consultant).
- Arbitrator Intelligence (2020-present) (Board of Advisors).
- Modus Endeavor (2019-present) (scientific consultant).
- AccessLex Institute (2016-2018) (consultant).
- LawyerMetrics, LLC (2011-2016) (co-founder).

References

Available upon request.

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Fulbright U.S. Scholar Award
Reference List

Dr. Christopher Zorn
Liberal Arts Professor, Department of Political Science
Affiliate Professor of Law and Information Science & Technology
Pennsylvania State University

Proposed Project: Institutionalization and Change in the Supreme Court of Namibia

References

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Dunia Prince Zongwe. "Thirty-Five Years Later: Why Namibia Must Now Choose Ubuntu's Soul." *African Law Matters*. https://www.africanlawmatters.com/blog/thirty-five-years-later-why-namibia-must-now-choose-ubuntus-soul (accessed August 21, 2026).

Eisenstadt, Schmuel Noah. 1964. "Institutionalization and Change." *American Sociological Review* 29(2): 235-47.

Irene Spigno. 2013. "Namibia: The Supreme Court as a Foreign Law Importer." In *The Use Of Foreign Precedents By Constitutional Judges*, eds. Tania Groppi and Marie-Claire Ponthoreau. Hart Publishing.

Laws.Africa. "Laws.Africa website." https://laws.africa/.

Mamdani, Mahmood. 1996. *Citizen and Subject: Contemporary Africa and the Legacy of Late Colonialism*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

McGuire, Kevin T. 2004. "The Institutionalization of the U.S. Supreme Court." *Political Analysis* 12(1): 128-42.

de Moraes, Thiago Maia Sayão, and Marcos de Moraes Sousa. 2024. "History Matters: The Institutionalization and Innovation Paradox in the Judiciary." *Social Sciences* 13(5): 247.

NamibLII. "Namibian Legal Information Institute website." https://namiblii.org/.

Okpaluba, Chuks. "Protecting the Right to Personal Liberty in Namibia: Constitutional, Delictual and Comparative Perspectives." *African Human Rights Law Journal* 14: 580-608.

Peter VonDoepp. 2009. *Judicial Politics in New Democracies: Cases from Southern Africa*. Lynne Rienner.

Ünlü, Hayati. 2024. "The Institutionalization of the Constitutional Court in Turkey." *Necmettin Erbakan Universitesi Siyasal Bilgiler Fakultesi Dergisi*: 2.

Warikandwa, Tapiwa Victor, and John Baloro. 2022. *Namibia's Supreme Court at 30 Years: A Review of the Superior Court's Role in the Development of Namibia's Jurisprudence in the Post-Independence Era*. Konrad Adenauer Stiftung.

van Wyk, Dawid. 1991. "The Making of the Namibian Constitution: Lessons for Africa." *The Comparative and International Law Journal of Southern Africa* 24(3): 341-51.

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PL SC 476: Empirical Legal Studies

Fall 2025

Professor Christopher Zorn
Department of Political Science
Pennsylvania State University
E-mail: zorn@psu.edu
Tuesdays and Thursdays, 9:05 p.m. - 10:20 a.m. ET
Chambers Building, Room 104

Course Description

The tools of social science affect both how scholars understand the workings of the judicial system and how lawyers practice law. This course engages students in the empirical study of law and the courts. It provides them with the substantive knowledge, and statistical and analytic skills they need to understand both (1) how social scientists use empirical evidence to make inferences about laws, judges, and legal institutions and (2) how statistical (and other empirical) methods are used in legal practice. Through the course, students will undertake statistical analyses and learn how to present these analyses to nontechnical audiences, such as jurors, employers, and the general public. The course begins with an overview of the social scientific study of law and the courts, and then investigates a series of topics, including how social science and empirical evidence are used to make legal claims and establish legal standards, to provide a context for judicial decisions, and to litigate cases.

This course is a Data Intensive course recommended for Bachelor of Science (BS) students in Political Science and for Social Data Analytics (SoDA). PLSC 309 or STAT 200 are required pre-requisites for this course.

All course materials (including this syllabus) will be available on a dedicated Github repo, which can be found at: https://github.com/PrisonRodeo/PLSC476-FA2025-git. Throughout this syllabus, hot links are in Penn State Blue.

Texts

Required:

Epstein, Lee, and Andrew D. Martin. 2015. *An Introduction to Empirical Legal Research*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Other readings as assigned, available on the course github repository.

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Recommended (i.e., potentially useful):

Agresti, Alan, and Barbara Finlay. 2008. *Statistical Methods for the Social Sciences*, 4th Ed. Upper Saddle River, NJ: Prentice-Hall.

Crawley, Michael J. 2013. *The R Book*, 2nd Ed. New York: Wiley.

Daalgard, Peter. 2008. *Introductory Statistics With R*, 2nd Ed. New York: Springer.

Everitt, Brian S., and Torsten Hothorn. 2015. *A Handbook of Statistical Analyses Using R*, 3rd Ed. Boca Raton, FL: Chapman & Hall.

Maindonald, John, and John Braun. 2013. *Data Analysis and Graphics Using R: An Example-Based Approach*, 3rd Ed. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Verzani, John. 2014. *Using R For Introductory Statistics*, 2nd Ed. Boca Raton, FL: Chapman & Hall.

Note as well that there are many, many books (and other resources) for learning data analysis and visualization, statistics, and/or R.

The Teaching Assistant

Tyler Suman is the teaching assistant for PLSC 476. He is a Political Science Ph.D. candidate who specializes in international relations and comparative politics, and in statistics and data science. He will serve as a "first line of defense" in the course: He can assist you with course material, software and programming issues, and other matters related to the course work. He can be reached via e-mail at `wts5131 [at] psu [dot] edu`.

Grading

For this course, grades will be assessed based on two broad categories:

- Four research modules / short papers (15% each)
- Either:
    1. A take-home final examination, or
    2. A course paper / project (40%)

More information regarding examinations, the course project / paper, and the scope and nature of the research modules and final examination will be presented in class and available on the course github repo. The instructor reserves the right to change the distribution of percentages across

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course components as necessary. Students unable to complete the final exam at the scheduled times must obtain permission to do so **prior to the exam / due date** so that alternative arrangements may be made.

While course grades will not include a "class participation" component, classroom engagement and participation is essential to the success of this class.

Some Other Useful Resources

The **Inter-University Consortium for Political and Social Research** (ICPSR), at the University of Michigan, maintains an extensive archive of data in the social and behavioral sciences. Much of it is accessible via their homepage (`http://www.icpsr.umich.edu`).

The **Comprehensive R Archive Network** (CRAN) (`http://cran.r-project.org/`) is the place to go for downloads, packages, and documentation. Similarly, the **Stata**^{TM} homepage (`http://www.stata.com`) is a valuable resource for questions about Stata statistical software.

The Dataverse Project, and in particular the Harvard Dataverse, is a free, open-source repository for data and replication code from published and unpublished empirical work in the natural, physical, social, and behavioral sciences.

Obligatory Statement on Academic Integrity

Academic integrity is the pursuit of scholarly activity in an open, honest and responsible manner. Academic integrity is a basic guiding principle for all academic activity at The Pennsylvania State University, and all members of the University community are expected to act in accordance with this principle. Consistent with this expectation, the University's Code of Conduct states that all students should act with personal integrity, respect other students' dignity, rights and property, and help create and maintain an environment in which all can succeed through the fruits of their efforts.

Academic integrity includes a commitment by all members of the University community not to engage in or tolerate acts of falsification, misrepresentation or deception. Such acts of dishonesty violate the fundamental ethical principles of the University community and compromise the worth of work completed by others.

In cases of any violation of academic integrity it is the policy of the Department of Political Science to follow procedures established by the College of the Liberal Arts. More information on academic integrity and procedures followed for violation can be found here.

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Obligatory Statement on Accommodations for Disabilities

Penn State welcomes students with disabilities into the University's educational programs. Every Penn State campus has an office for students with disabilities. Student Disability Resources (SDR) website provides contact information for every Penn State campus (here). For further information, please visit the Student Disability Resources website (here).

In order to receive consideration for reasonable accommodations, you must contact the appropriate disability services office at the campus where you are officially enrolled, participate in an intake interview, and provide documentation: See documentation guidelines here. If the documentation supports your request for reasonable accommodations, your campus disability services office will provide you with an accommodation letter. Please share this letter with your instructors and discuss the accommodations with them as early as possible. You must follow this process for every semester that you request accommodations.

Obligatory Statement on Counseling and Psychological Services

Many students at Penn State face personal challenges or have psychological needs that may interfere with their academic progress, social development, or emotional wellbeing. The university offers a variety of confidential services to help you through difficult times, including individual and group counseling, crisis intervention, consultations, online chats, and mental health screenings. These services are provided by staff who welcome all students and embrace a philosophy respectful of clients' cultural and religious backgrounds, and sensitive to differences in race, ability, gender identity and sexual orientation.

Counseling and Psychological Services at University Park (CAPS)
(http://studentaffairs.psu.edu/counseling/): 814-863-0395

Counseling and Psychological Services at Commonwealth Campuses
(http://senate.psu.edu/faculty/counseling-services-at-commonwealth-campuses/)

Penn State Crisis Line (24 hours / 7 days/week): 877-229-6400. Crisis Text Line (24 hours / 7 days/week): Text LIONS to 741741.

Obligatory Statement on Educational Equity and Reporting Bias

Penn State takes great pride to foster a diverse and inclusive environment for students, faculty, and staff. Consistent with University Policy AD29, students who believe they have experienced or observed a hate crime, an act of intolerance, discrimination, or harassment that occurs at Penn State are urged to report these incidents as outlined on the University's Report Bias webpage (http://equity.psu.edu/reportbias/).

Obligatory Statement on Religious Observances

The Religious and Spiritual Observances Calendar is compiled by the Center for Spiritual and Ethical Development in consultation with campus and community religious leaders. It specifies those holy days of the major world religions for which observance may require students to depart from their normal routine at the University. Please note that only those holy days which occur when Penn State classes are in session are listed. This is not, therefore, an exhaustive list of all major holy days in each religious tradition.

Non-Obligatory Statement on Generative AI, Large Language Models, etc.

You're undoubtedly well aware of the existence of large language models (LLMs) – e.g., ChatGPT – and other artificial intelligence (AI) tools for language / image creation. Having been described as everything from making everyone their own version of Tony Stark to a Lovecraftian shoggoth (and most things in between), LLMs are currently creating a sometimes-depressing, sometimes-hilarious panic among faculty in legacy academic disciplines and programs. Most of that panic revolves around the use of LLMs to "cheat," in the traditional sense: to create work that deceptively gives the impression that the student knows something they do not. Beyond its intrinsically duplicitous nature, such use in a conventional classroom setting gives rise to concerns about equity and (potentially) devalues the experience / credential for other class members.

The other side of the LLM equation is that they are powerful tools for augmenting learning and creating new knowledge. Experience suggests that, in line with other technological advances (the printing press, personal computers, search engines, etc.), it is wiser to adapt to LLMs than to attempt to limit or ban their use. This is especially true in a course like this one, where (a) LLMs are particularly useful tools for learning technical skills (e.g., the R programming language) and (b) the long-term, repeated nature of graduate school creates disincentives for "cheating" in a conventional sense. Accordingly, enrollees in PLSC 476 are welcome to use generative AI tools, such as ChatGPT, to assist them with their work in the course. In doing so, it is important to remember that such AI tools are capable of making errors, and that it is each student's responsibility to verify the information they receive from the such a tool. In addition, any information obtained from a generative AI source must be noted/cited in the student's work, just as they would cite any other source.

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Course Schedule

Daily reading assignments are listed for each class session. Note that reading assignments are listed according to the day on which the subject matter will be discussed; they should therefore be read prior to that date.

I. Some Preliminaries

August 26: Course Introduction

- No readings assigned.

August 28: Review of the R Language

- No readings assigned.

September 2: Review: Data Analysis and Statistics

- Review material from PLSC 309 / STAT 200, and/or chapters 2, 3, and 6 of Epstein and Martin (2015).
- Groeneveld, Richard A., and Glen Meeden. 1977. "The Mode, Median, and Mean Inequality." *The American Statistician* 31(3):120-21.
- Nagler, Jonathan. 1995. "Coding Style and Good Computing Practices." *The Political Methodologist* 6(2):2-8.

September 4: Review: Data Visualization

- Agresti, Alan, and Barbara Finlay. 2008. *Statistical Methods for the Social Sciences*, 4th Ed. Upper Saddle River, NJ: Prentice-Hall. pp. 31-38.
- Fox, John. 2008. *Applied Regression Analysis and Generalized Linear Models*, 2nd Ed. Newbury Park, CA: Sage Publications. pp. 28-50.
- Epstein and Martin (2015), Chapters 10 and 11 (review quickly).

II. Judges, Courts, and Judicial Institutions

September 9: Overview of Empirical Research on Judicial Politics

- Epstein and Martin (2015), Chapter 1.

September 11: Introduction to Judicial Decision-Making

- Baum, Lawrence. 1997. *The Puzzle of Judicial Behavior*. Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press. Chapter 1.

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September 16: Digression: So You Want To Go To Law School?

- The LSAC's Panglossian Summary of Law School Admissions.
- ABA-disclosed "509 reports," bar passage information, and employment data.
- The xtranormal version.

September 18: Practicum: Finding and Working With Court Data

- No readings assigned.

September 23: Judicial Behavior: Personal Attributes

- Tate, C. Neal. 1981. "Personal Attribute Models of the Voting Behavior of U.S. Supreme Court Justices: Liberalism in Civil Liberties and Economics Decisions." *American Political Science Review* 75(June):355-67.
- Glynn, Adam, and Maya Sen. 2015. "Identifying Judicial Empathy: Does Having Daughters Cause Judges to Rule for Women's Issues?" *American Journal of Political Science* 59:37-54.

September 25: Practicum – Personal Attribute Models

- No readings assigned.

September 30: Political Ideology and Judicial Behavior

- Segal, Jeffrey A., and Albert Cover. 1989. "Ideological Values and the Votes of U.S. Supreme Court Justices." *American Political Science Review* 83:557-65.
- Segal, Jeffrey A., Lee Epstein, Charles M. Cameron, and Harold J. Spaeth. 1995. "Ideological Values and the Votes of U.S. Supreme Court Justices Revisited." *Journal of Politics* 57:812-23.

October 2: Practicum – Political Ideology and Judicial Behavior

- No readings assigned.

October 7: Precedent and Legal Influences

- Segal Jeffrey A. 1984. "Predicting Supreme Court Cases Probabilistically: The Search and Seizure Cases, 1962-1981." *American Political Science Review* 78:891-900.
- George, Tracey, and Lee Epstein. 1992. "On the Nature of Supreme Court Decision Making." *American Political Science Review* 86:323-37.

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- Segal, Jeffrey A., and Harold J. Spaeth. 1996. "The Influence of Stare Decisis on the Votes of United States Supreme Court Justices." *American Journal of Political Science* 40:971-1003.

October 9: Practicum – Legal Influences

- No readings assigned.

October 14: Courts and Public Opinion

- McGuire, Kevin T., and James A. Stimson. 2004. "The Least Dangerous Branch Revisited: New Evidence on Supreme Court Responsiveness to Public Preferences." *Journal of Politics* 66:1018-35.
- Canes-Wrone, Brandice, Tom S. Clark, and Jason P. Kelly. 2014. "Judicial Selection and Death Penalty Decisions." *American Political Science Review* 108:23-39.

October 16: Practicum – Courts and Public Opinion

- No readings assigned.

October 21: Courts and the Separation of Powers

- Epstein, Lee, Jack Knight, and Andrew D. Martin. 2001. "The Supreme Court As A Strategic National Policy Maker." *Emory Law Journal* 50:583-611.
- Clark, Tom. 2009. "The Separation of Powers, Court-Curbing and Judicial Legitimacy." *American Journal of Political Science* 53:971-89.

October 23: Practicum – Courts and the Separation of Powers

- No readings assigned.

October 28: Digression: Public Defenders in PA

- Enos, Emma, and Christopher Zorn. 2023. "Crippling Gideon: The Political Economy of Locally-Funded Public Defenders."

October 30: No Class – Wellness Day

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III. Empirical Analysis and Legal Practice

November 4: Legal Education

- Marks, Alexia Brunet, and Scott A. Moss. 2016. "What Predicts Law Student Success: A Longitudinal Study Correlating Law Student Applicant Data and Law School Outcomes." *Journal of Empirical Legal Studies* 13:205-265.
- Sheldon, Kennon M., and Lawrence S. Krieger. 2004. "Does Legal Education Have Undermining Effects on Law Students? Evaluating Changes in Motivation, Values, and Well-Being." *Behavioral Sciences and the Law* 22:261-286.
- Also: Play around with this.

November 6: Practicum – Legal Education

- No readings assigned.

November 11: Law Firm Hiring

- Ginsburg, Tom, and Jeffrey A. Wolf. 2004. "The Market for Elite Law Firm Associates." *Florida State University Law Review* 31:909-963.

November 13: Legal Careers

- Monahan, John, and Jeffrey Swanson. 2019. "Lawyers at the Peak of Their Careers: A 30-Year Longitudinal Study of Job and Life Satisfaction." *Journal of Empirical Legal Studies* 16:4-25.

November 18: Legal Practice – Criminal Law

- Dressel, Julia, and Hany Farid. 2018. "The Accuracy, Fairness, and Limits of Predicting Recidivism." *Science Advances* 4: no. 1.
- Lin, Zhiyuan "Jerry," Jongbin Jung, Sharad Goel, and Jennifer Skeem. 2020. "The Limits of Human Predictions of Recidivism." *Science Advances* 6: no. 7.

November 20: Practicum – Criminal Law

- No readings assigned.

November 25: No Class – Thanksgiving Break

November 27: No Class – Thanksgiving Break

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December 2: Legal Practice: Civil Litigation

- "Electronic discovery" at Wikipedia (yes, you read that right).
- The EDRM process (poster)
- Kinsey, Casey. 2020. "The Role of Machine Learning in Legal Discovery." *Lofty Labs blog*.
- Dale, Robert. 2018. "Law and Word Order: NLP in Legal Tech." *Towards Data Science* blog, December 15, 2018.

December 4: Practicum – Civil Litigation

- No readings assigned.

December 9: The Law Business

- Chambliss, Elizabeth. 2019. "Evidence-Based Lawyer Regulation." *Washington University Law Review* 97:297-350.[1]

December 11: Catch-Up, Wrap-Up, and Review

- No readings assigned.

December 17: Final Exams / Projects Due

[1]If you like this, you should also read Renee Newman Knake (2018) "The Legal Monopoly," *Washington University Law Review* 93:1293-1337, and Gillian Hadfield (2008), "Legal Barriers to Innovation," *Regulation* Fall:14-21.

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UNAM
UNIVERSITY OF NAMIBIA

01 September 2026

Dr Christopher Zorn
Department of Political Science
Pennsylvania State University
137 Fischer Road
University Park, PA 16802
USA

SUBJECT: INVITATION TO JOIN THE UNIVERSITY OF NAMIBIA AS A VISITING FULBRIGHT U.S. SCHOLAR – 2028

Dear Dr. Zorn

On behalf of the Vice Chancellor, Prof. Dr. Kenneth K. Matengu, it is a pleasure to extend you a formal invitation to the University of Namibia (UNAM), from the 01st of February 2028 to the 30th of November 2028, as part of the Fulbright U.S. Scholars Program.

While at UNAM, you will conduct independent research on *Institutionalization and Change in the Supreme Court of Namibia*, in collaboration with Dr Kennedy Kariseb, Associate Dean: School of Law. You will also teach courses within the School of Law that are aligned with your academic areas of expertise, to be identified at a later stage. While here, you will also have the opportunity to interact with students and faculty members in the school and the wider UNAM community. Please note that we will provide you with a workspace as well as library and internet access; however, you will be required to supply your own laptop computer. Kindly be informed that this appointment does not require you to pay any bench or lab fees.

We look forward to your arrival at UNAM, and trust that undertaking your research and teaching will be a rewarding experience, and will build greater bonds between our universities.

Yours sincerely,

Marius Kudumo
Director: Corporate Engagement & International Relations